



Shantanu Narayen

Chair & Chief Executive Officer (transitioning — see note)

1982

Founded

31.4K

Employees

\$23.8B

FY2025 revenue

\$25.2B

Ending ARR

\$5B+

AI-influenced ARR

01 Who You're Meeting

Shantanu Narayen — Chair & Chief Executive Officer (transitioning — see note), Adobe.

In role: CEO since 1 December 2007; announced 12 March 2026 that he will transition once a successor is appointed, remaining Chair

Today: Leads Adobe through a second platform transition — from the cloud/subscription model he built to generative AI embedded across Creative Cloud, Document Cloud and Experience Cloud.

An engineer turned operator who has run Adobe for eighteen years and is credited as the architect of its shift to software-as-a-service. He joined Adobe in 1998 as VP and General Manager of the engineering technology group, becoming SVP worldwide products in 1999, EVP in 2001 and President & COO in January 2005 before taking the CEO role. Before Adobe he co-founded Pictra Inc., an early digital photo-sharing company, and held roles at Silicon Graphics and Apple. He holds five patents.

Career: Chief Executive Officer (Chair from 2017), Adobe; President & Chief Operating Officer, Adobe; VP & GM engineering technology, then SVP/EVP worldwide products, Adobe; Co-founder, Pictra Inc.

The company: The incumbent in creative software, now in the awkward position of being both an AI winner and an AI disruption target. AI-influenced ARR passed \$5B in FY2025 — over a third of the total base — while the market prices the stock at a decade-low forward multiple on the view that generative tools will erode the moat.

What they sell: Creative Cloud, Document Cloud and Experience Cloud, with the Firefly generative model family embedded across them. Enterprise AI is sold through Firefly Services, Firefly Foundry (brand-specific custom models trained on a customer's own IP) and GenStudio. Acrobat Studio, released August 2025, folds AI agents into document workflows.

02 Where The Company Sits

Adobe's defensible claim is provenance, not capability: its models are trained on content it owns or has licensed, which makes output commercially safe in a way that matters to regulated buyers and to anyone indemnifying downstream use. It has also stopped insisting Firefly be the only option — the Generative Media Tool in Premiere lets users pick Google Veo, Kling, Runway or Luma instead. That is a confident move if the platform is the moat and a concession if the model was.

03 Talking Points

- He is a transitioning CEO: strategic commitments made now may outlast him, so establish who else owns the relationship.
- He led one platform transition successfully (perpetual to subscription) and is being judged on whether he can lead a second.
- The defensible Adobe claim is commercially-safe training data, not model capability — pitch to indemnity and brand risk.

What to pressure-test about the company:

- The market is pricing disruption: a forward P/E around 12–14x is a ten-year low for this business
- CEO succession is unresolved — Shantanu Narayen announced on 12 March 2026 that he will transition once a successor is appointed, and shares fell 7% on the news
- AI-first ARR, while growing fast, is roughly 2% of total ARR — the base business still carries the company

04 GIP Context

GIP: No publicly disclosed GIP relationship. Adobe's relevance to an infrastructure portfolio is corporate-function rather than asset-level — marketing, documents and contract workflows — which places it in the Individual Productivity and Corporate Functions Efficiency areas of the reference model, not Asset Optimization.

BlackRock: No publicly disclosed operating relationship; standard index holdings only.

www.adobe.com · [CEO transition announcement](#) · [Adobe Q4 FY25 earnings transcript](#) · [Company LinkedIn](#)

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